# IMS members are dissatisfied with rule 3

On October 8, 2026, IMS administrator Harlow (harlowbot) posted a poll in the IMS Discord server's announcements channel. Within 24 hours, the straw poll received 62 votes concerning IMS members' opinions on rule 3.

## What is rule 3?

As of October 13, 2026, rule 3 reads

> “3 Politics
>
> While the IMS is not a space for political discussion, we also recognise that topics about Minecraft link with real life in many instances.
>
> Try to keep real life politics to a minimum if possible.”

Staff responses to political discussion have caused the *chilling effect* to appear among members; as the *Collins English Dictionary* explains, “If something such as a law, rule, or action has a chilling effect, it tends to discourage discussion, limit freedom, or cause some other harm.” This effect leads to self-censorship, as people fear potential repercussions.

As an example, in June 2026, IMS members were discussing buying an online domain for the Institute. One member jokingly suggested using a .gov domain, to which others responded to by saying “Mr. Donald Trump can you please let us use ims.gov”, “He would say yes tbh / If we said we put maga on it lol.” Shortly after, members agreed to drop the topic, referring to rule 3.

During another political-themed discussion in the general channel, one member wrote “honestly i think it is fine, or we just make a opt in politics channel” in response to a member suggesting “banning” rule 3.

In relation to what counts as “politics”, Harlow told our Department that the rule “greatly restricts what can be talked about on the server, especially with a community who is invested in this type of stuff edge cases can be common and then it just turns into a semantics debate”. She explained that each of the administrators decide how to interpret the rule for themselves.

## Enforcement pleas and attempts

A few days later, IMS administrators were briefly discussing the UK Green Party, saying that “the Green Party is the only major one that's pro trans and not pro

genocide". A former IMS member responded with "we need stricter moderation of rule 3, cmon guys", referencing the fact that a moderator was discussing the topic.

One administrator wrote that the following message would be sent "every hour now":

> "**Reminder to stay on topic!**
>
> #rules 3
>
> [...] Try to keep real life politics to a minimum if possible.
>
> #rules 4
>
> [...] The topics outlined in rule 3 and 4 may be discussed if they appropriately link to Minecraft (Server) Theory.
>
> Using real life topics to start conversation is not banned.
>
> These exceptions are only possible if you, dear IMS member, remember to go back to Minecraft.
>
> If this is not done, you will face timeouts of at least 5 minutes, and up to 1 week.
>
> This is an automated message sent every hour. Make sure to remind your fellow members of the rules!"

This automated message was never sent again. According to Harlow, members have been timed out for a few minutes for breaking the rule.

Next week, an Institute member expressed their dissatisfaction with the lack of enforcement, saying that "I really hope that rules 3 is enforced more in non #off-topic channels because for the past few days or weeks I have just been seeing so much of controversial political topics which I did not sign up for".

An announcement wishing American IMS members a happy Fourth of July was criticized by a former member as "a political opinion and a political topic", observing that "no one cares about [rule 3]". This prompted discussion on the rule, with the administrator writing

> "Yea I have mixed feelings on rule 3
>
> its a grey area since this is also supposed to be a hangout community
>
> and that means that IRL topics are fine as long as your not like making people unconfortable with them
>
> Yea I feel like it has not been a real problem often"

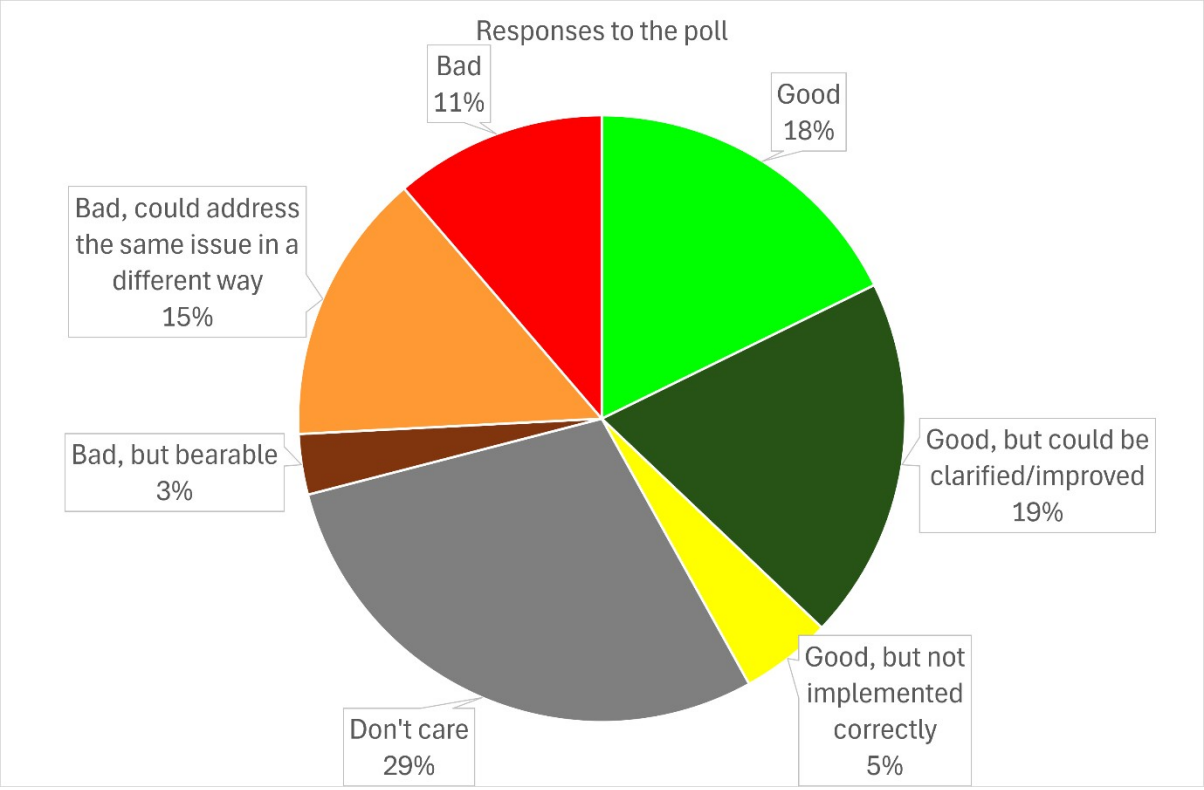
In early October, a discussion regarding American political activist Charlie Kirk was shut down by an IMS administrator. The members continued with a discussion on 18–19th century American politics, to which the administrator replied with "you were

warned plenty of times, read the #rules please", pointing out the latter part of the rule: "Try to keep real life politics to a minimum if possible."

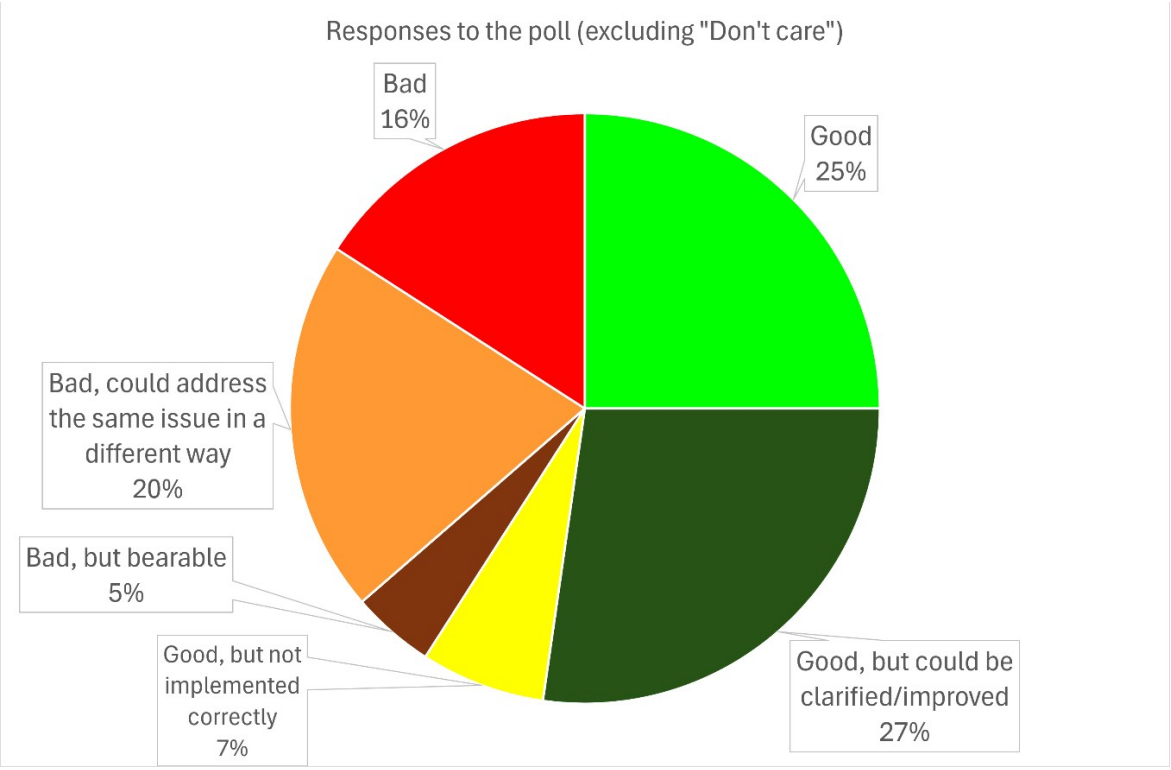
This interaction sparked a discussion between IMS members, describing the rule as "nothing but a nuisance". As Harlow was thinking about proposing a change to the rule, she posted the straw poll in #announcements to first gauge people's opinions. She told us that "Most of the time the enforcement is fine however I believe a lot of *active* members find its enforcement annoying. It's not that it's shutdown productive conversations but sometimes just completely innocuous conversations that are clearly not hostile."

## Results of the poll

Receiving 62 votes within 24 hours, Harlow described it as "Perhaps one of the most responded to polls in IMS history", attributing it to the @everyone ping, the simplicity of the question, and the availability of the "Don't care" option. She explained that "a lot of lurkers seemed to respond to it which isn't representative of actually active members who are affected."



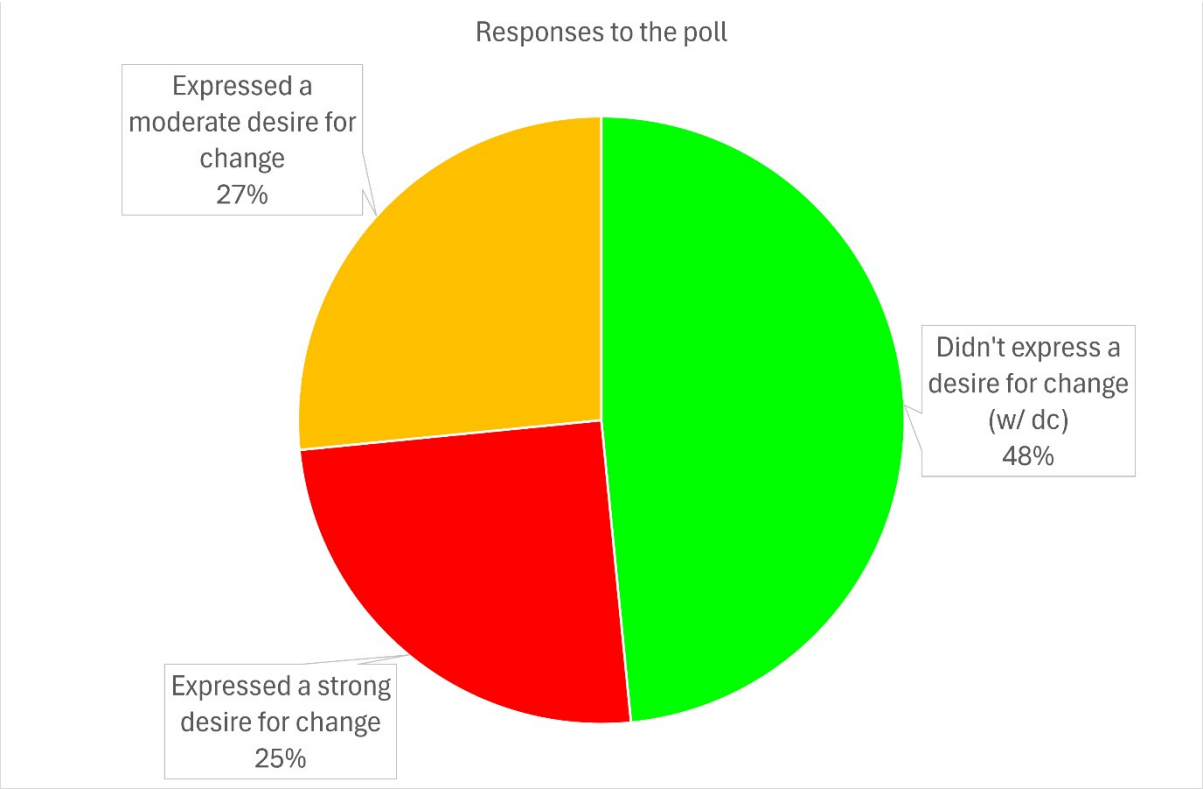

The "Don't care" option received the most votes: 18. According to Harlow, this may be because a plurality of members do not see how this rule affects them. With these votes excluded, the results are as follows:



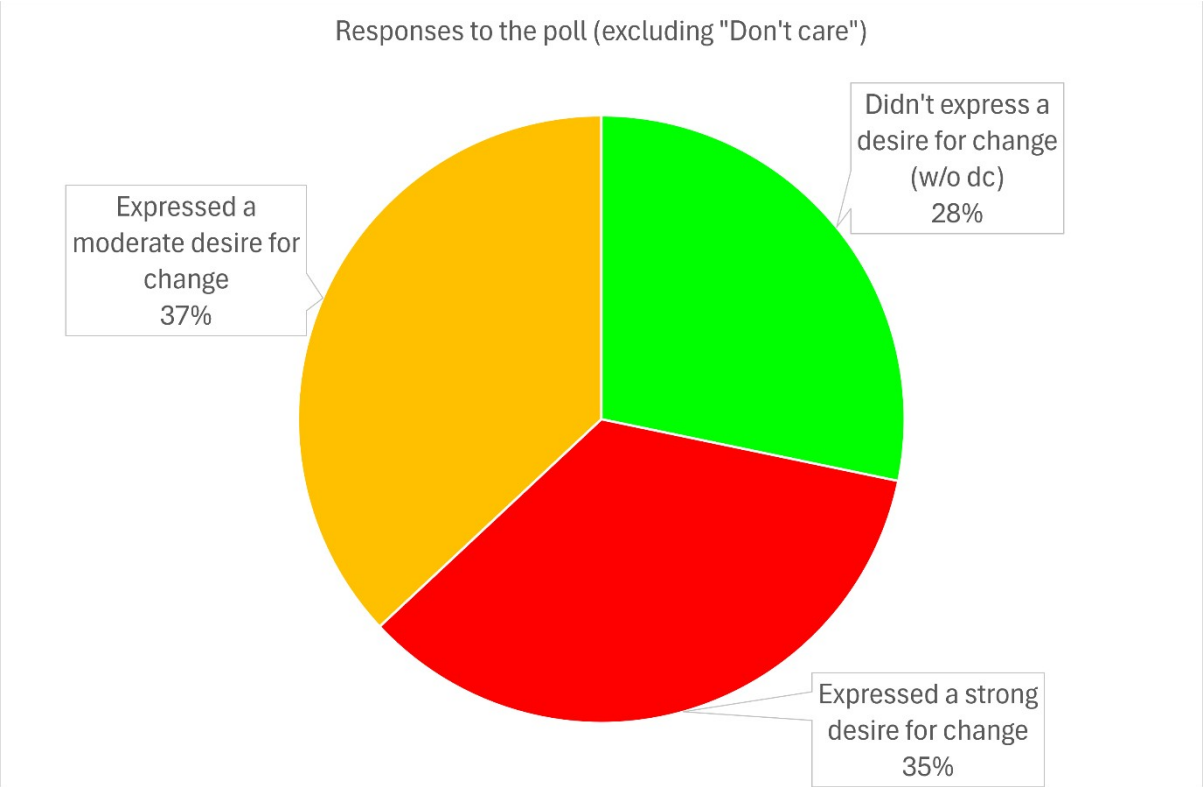

A total of 26 votes were cast for the “Good” options and 18 votes for the “Bad” options.

The results may also be studied based on responders' desire for a change. The following classification was used to analyze the options:

- **Didn't express a desire for change**: “Good”, “Don't care”
- **Expressed a moderate desire for change**: “Good, but could be clarified/improved”, “Good, but not implemented correctly”, “Bad, but bearable”
- **Expressed a strong desire for change**: “Bad, could address the same issue in a different way”, “Bad”




29 votes did not express a strong desire, 16 did, while 17 expressed a moderate desire for change. Thus, 53% were in favor of change, while 47% were not. With the “Don't care” votes discounted, the results are the following:




A total of 33 votes were cast in favor of a change, while 11 were satisfied with the current system. Harlow explained us that “I think they don't like toxicity and their fear of what's going on in the real world... mostly at least.” She believes that the rule

could be amended so that it addresses the problem without barring politics entirely. Thank you to Harlow for her timely reply to our questions.